



Of course. HIL is a commercial venture, and everyone wants it to be like the Indian Premier League (IPL). It's still in its early stages, but the response so far has been good. For the first two or three years, the teams may not make a profit, which will happen slowly. We're also planning a better league model that eases the financial burden on franchises.

Women's hockey was doing well earlier but has dipped in performance lately. What are your plans for them?

We need to strengthen our grassroots programmes for both men and women. To build strong national teams, we must nurture players at the U-15, U-17 and U-19 levels. The coaching programme needs to be improved to give them better exposure; only then will we get quality players.

We're developing one where the U-17 and U-19 core groups will train together.

There will also be U-21 and India A teams. All players cannot be part of the Indian team, so there will be a chain.

We have a lot of heritage tournaments such as the Beighton Cup and the Aga Khan Cup. How can we use these to benefit our players?

Indian hockey is alive because of such tournaments. I don't think there are so many tournaments in any other country. We need renowned players to participate in these events to attract spectators. There are so many tournaments that national players can't feature in all of them, such as the National Championships. We've tried to make it compulsory for players to take part in the Nationals to maintain the

Key to success: "To build strong national teams, we must nurture players at the U-15, U-17 and U-19 levels," said Dilip Tirkey. R.V. MOOTHY

standard of quality, and we'll continue to do so.

How is HI preparing for upcoming major tournaments?

Next year, both the World Cup and the Asian Games are crucial. We're talking to the chief coach and working on a plan.

India has expressed interest in hosting the 2036 Olympics. Have you begun planning with that in mind?

Yes, absolutely. Hockey fans will expect a strong performance. With the 2032 and 2036 Olympics coming up, we need to start work accordingly.